Lesson 7

Belief/Salvation

"For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life*."*
(John 3:16)

Belief: the acceptance or conviction that certain things (or claims) are true or real

What you believe has a profound influence on your entire existence. If you believe in Jesus Christ, when you die you will go to heaven and live forever in paradise with God. If you do not believe in Him, when you die you will go to hell where you will be separated from God and suffer for eternity. Given this alternative, it is staggering that more people do not thoroughly evaluate the evidence for the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ, as told in the Holy Bible.

Synopsis

The story of Jesus Christ begins at the point of creation. Jesus was with God (and the Holy Spirit) when the world and everything in it was created—including mankind.[1,2] When God saw the world and all that He had made, He said that it was "good."[3] Unfortunately, it did not stay that way for long.

In the beginning was the Word [Jesus], and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.
(John 1:1)[1]

He was with God in the beginning.
(John 1:2)[2]

God saw all that he had made, and it was very good.
(Genesis 1:31)[3]

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Adam and Eve, the first man and woman, disobeyed God in the Garden of Eden, when they "gave in" to Satan's temptation[4,5] and ate the fruit that God had forbidden them to eat.[6] At that point, sin entered into the world. As a result, all human beings inherit a sinful nature and all human beings suffer a physical death.[7]

God cannot tolerate sin.[8] Therefore, the fall of mankind into sin separated us from the all-loving God who created us. Because of this separation, our Heavenly Father, in His great mercy, decided to send His one and only son, Jesus Christ[9,10] to take away the sins of the world[11,12] so that our relationship with Him could be restored.[13,14]

Now the serpent [Satan] was more crafty than any of the wild animals the LORD God had made. He said to the woman, "Did God really say, 'You must not eat from any tree in the garden'?"
(Genesis 3:1)[4]

"You will not surely die," the serpent said to the woman. For God knows that when you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil.
(Genesis 3:4)[5]

When the woman [Eve] saw that the fruit of the tree was good for food and pleasing to the eye, and also desirable for gaining wisdom, she took some and ate it. She also gave some to her husband [Adam], who was with her, and he ate it.
(Genesis 3:6)[6]

For as in Adam all die, so in Christ all will be made alive.
(1 Corinthians 15:22)[7]

Bur your iniquities have separated you form your God;
your sins have hidden his face from you,
so that he will not hear.
(Isaiah 59:2)[8]

I have not come on my own; but he sent me.
(John 8:42)[9]

This is love: not that we loved God, but that he loved us and sent his Son as an atoning sacrifice for our sins.
(1 John 4:10)[10]

He appeared so that he might take away our sins.
(1 John 3:5)[11]

Jesus entered this world as a human baby.[15] Through the power of the Holy Spirit, a young woman named Mary, a virgin, miraculously became pregnant with Jesus,[16] and later gave birth to Him in the city of Bethlehem. When He was born, an angel of the Lord told Mary to name her new baby "Jesus," [which literally means, "Jehovah saves"], "because He will save His people from their sins." (Matthew 1:21)

As Jesus grew up, He shared in our human experience. He was all-God,[17] yet all-human. He was tempted in every way that man is tempted,[18] and He felt pain and human emotions.[19] However, unlike man, Jesus was perfect, and did not sin.[20]

Look, the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world!
(John 1:29)[12]

But we also rejoice in God through our Lord Jesus Christ,
through whom we have now received reconciliation.
(Romans 5:11)[13]

In him [Christ] and through faith in him we may
approach God with freedom and confidence.
(Ephesians 3:12)[14]

The Word [Jesus] became flesh and made his dwelling among us.
(John 1:14)[15]

She [Mary]was found to be with child through the Holy Spirit.
(Matthew 1:18)[16]

I and the Father are one.
(John 10:30)[17]

Because he himself suffered when he was tempted,
he is able to help those who are being tempted.
(Hebrews 2:18)[18]

During the days of Jesus' life on earth, he offered up prayers and petitions with loud cries and tears to the one who could save him from death, and he was heard because of his reverent submission.
(Hebrews 5:7)[19]

For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize
with our weaknesses, but we have one who has been tempted
in every way, just as we are—yet was without sin.
(Hebrews 4:15)[20]

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Throughout his ministry on earth, Jesus told people about God and why He was sent to this earth.[21,22] He urged people to repent of their sins, and turn from their evil ways.[23] He made it very clear that the only way human beings could restore their relationship with God was through belief in Him, and in Him only.[24,25]

Jesus preached that if people would believe in Him, they would be "born again."[26] He urged them to be baptized as an outward expression of their spiritual cleansing and "rebirth."[27] He made it clear that the process of being "born again" is essential to salvation.[26] When we accept Jesus Christ as our Lord and Savior, we are a new creation, and life is never the same again.[28]

I have come into the world as a light, so that no one who believes in me should stay in darkness.
(John 12:46)[21]

I have come so that they may have life, and have it to the full.
(John 10:10)[22]

The kingdom of God is near. Repent and believe the good news*!*
(Mark 1:15)[23]

I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me.
(John 14:6)[24]

I am the gate; whoever enters through me will be saved.
(John 10:9)[25]

I tell you the truth, no one can see the kingdom of God unless he is born again.
(John 3:3)[26]

I tell you the truth, no one can enter the kingdom unless he is born of water and the Spirit.
(John 3:5)[27]

Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; the old has gone, the new has come!
(2 Corinthians 5:17)[28]

During his time on earth, Jesus performed many miracles in the hope that people would see His power, and realize that He was not just any ordinary man—but that He was divine.[29] Unfortunately, many people did not recognize His divine nature or believe in Him, even after the awesome miracles he performed.[30,31] Even His own brothers did not believe in Him.[32]

As time passed, people began to hate Jesus for no reason[33] and plotted to kill Him. They looked for evidence against Him,[34] even though He was entirely innocent and sinless[35] and did nothing to deserve such treatment.[33]

Jesus was arrested, tried and convicted of heresy, and sentenced to death by crucifixion. He endured incredible suffering. He was stripped and flogged.[36] They spit on Him and struck Him on the

Do not believe me unless I do what my Father does. But if I do it, even though you do not believe me, believe the miracles, that you may know and understand that the Father is in me, and I in the Father.
(John 10:37-38)[29]

He was in the world, and though the world was made through him, the world did not recognize him.
(John 1:10)[30]

Even after Jesus had done all these miraculous signs in their presence, they still would not believe in him.
(John 12:37)[31]

For even his own brothers did not believe in him.
(John 7:5)[32]

But now they have seen these miracles, and yet they have hated both me and my Father. But this is to fulfill what is written in their Law: "*They hated me without reason.*"
(John 15:24-25)[33]

The chief priests and the whole Sanhedrin were looking for false evidence against Jesus so that they could put him to death.
(Matthew 26:59)[34]

God made him who had no sin to be sin for us.
(2 Corinthians 5:21)[35]

Then Pilate took Jesus and had him flogged.
(John 19:1)[36]

head repeatedly.[37] They mocked Him and crucified Him.[38] He died an excruciatingly painful death[39,40] and was buried in a tomb.[41]

On the third day after His death, the followers of Jesus went to His tomb and found that it was empty. Jesus had miraculously risen from the dead.[42] He appeared to His disciples in his "glorified body" and proved to them, on a number of occasions, that He was not dead, but alive.[43] On the 40th day after His death, Jesus ascended into heaven to sit at the right hand of God the Father Almighty.[44]

They spit on him, and took the staff and struck
him on the head again and again.
(Matthew 27:30)[37]

After they had mocked him, they took off the robe and put his own clothes on him. Then they led him away to crucify him.
(Matthew 27:31)[38]

And when Jesus had cried out again in a loud voice,
he gave up his spirit.
(Matthew 27:50)[39]

But when they [the Roman soldiers] came to Jesus and found that he was already dead, they did not break his legs. Instead, one of the soldiers pierced Jesus' side with a spear, bringing a sudden flow of blood and water.
(John 19:33-34)[40]

As evening approached, there came a rich man from Arimathea, named Joseph, who had himself become a disciple of Jesus. Going to Pilate, he asked for Jesus' body, and Pilate ordered that it be given to him. Joseph took the body, wrapped it n a clean linen cloth, and placed it in his own new tomb that he had cut out of the rock. He rolled a big stone in front of the entrance of the tomb and went away.
(Matthew 27:57-60).[41]

The angel said to the women, "Do not be afraid, for I know that you are looking for Jesus, who was crucified. He is not here; he has risen, just as he said."
(Matthew 28:5-6)[42]

After his suffering, he showed himself to these men and gave many convincing proofs that he was alive. He appeared to them over a period of forty days and spoke about the kingdom of God.
(Acts 1:3)[43]

The disciples of Jesus were first-hand witnesses to His life, death, and resurrection.[45] They were certain of what they saw and heard, and they went on to preach the "good news" of the gospel of Jesus Christ throughout the nations of the world.[46]

The good news is this: while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.[47] Anyone who believes in Him, will receive forgiveness of sins,[48] will be reconciled with God,[49] and will live forever in heaven.[50]

When Jesus went to be with the Father, He did not leave us alone. He promised that He would send the Holy Spirit, the great Counselor, who would live and dwell within the hearts of all believers.[51]

While he was blessing them, he left them
and was taken up into heaven.
(Luke 24:51)[44]

The man [the apostle John] who saw it [the crucifixion]
has given testimony, and his testimony is true. He
knows that he tells the truth, and he testifies so
that you also may believe.
(John 19:35)[45]

We did not follow cleverly invented stories when we
told you about the power and coming of our
Lord Jesus Christ, but we were
eyewitnesses of his majesty.
(2 Peter 1:16)[46]

But God demonstrates his own love for us in this:
while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.
(Romans 5:8)[47]

Everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness
of sins through his name.
(Acts 10:43)[48]

God was reconciling the world to himself in Christ,
not counting men's sins against them.
(2 Corinthians 5:19)[49]

I tell you the truth, he who believes
has everlasting life. **(John 6:47)[50]**

And I will ask the Father, and he will give
you another Counselor to be with you
forever—the Spirit of truth. **(John 14: 16-17)[51]**

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The Holy Spirit guides us into all truth[50] and testifies with our spirit that we are God's children.[51]

At some point in the future (at a time unknown to man) Jesus Christ will again return to earth (the "second coming of Christ") to bring salvation for those who are saved and who are waiting for His return.[52] Importantly, when He returns He will pass a final judgment on all mankind—those who are still living, and those who have died.[53] This fact is of utmost importance!

When Jesus returns again, if you have not yet received Him into your heart and believe that He died for your sins, you will be condemned to hell for eternity.[54] On the other hand, if you confess with your mouth, "Jesus is Lord," and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead, you will be saved." [55]

But when he, the Spirit of truth, comes, he will guide you into all truth.
(James 16:13)[50]

The Spirit himself testifies with our spirit that we are God's children.
(Romans 8:16)[51]

And he [Jesus] will appear a second time, not to bear sin, but to bring salvation to those who are waiting for him.
(Hebrews 9:27-28)[52]

For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, that each one may receive what is due him for the things done while in the body, whether good or bad.
(2 Corinthians 5:10)[53]

They will be punished with everlasting destruction and shut out from the presence of the Lord and from the majesty of his power on the day he comes to be glorified in his holy people and to be marveled at among all those who have believed.
(2 Thessalonians 1:9-10)[54]

If you confess with your mouth, "Jesus is Lord," and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.
(Romans 10:9)[55]

Importantly, God desires that *all* men be saved and come to a knowledge of truth.[56,57] That includes you, and everyone on this planet. Whoever believes in Jesus Christ and the one who sent him, crosses over from death into eternal life.[58]

Conclusion

There are no magic words that you can say that will get you into heaven, and save you from hell. Only a sincere belief that Christ is Lord, the Son of the Living God, and that He died on the cross for your sins, and was raised from the dead by God, will secure eternal salvation and life everlasting. If you sincerely believe these things, the following prayer is offered to help express what has already taken place in your heart.

The "Sinner's Prayer"

I confess that I am a sinner. I sincerely repent of all my wrongdoings. I believe that you sent Jesus Christ, your one and only Son, to die for my sins on the cross in Calvary. I believe that Jesus is Lord, and that you raised Him from the dead after His crucifixion. I believe that He sits at your right hand in heaven, and that when I die, I will see Jesus 'face-to-face," and dwell in your house forever.

A Final Word…

If this is the first time that you have accepted Jesus Christ as your Lord and Savior, it is important to understand that you may come under increasing attack by the Evil One (the Devil). Pray to God for strength to resist Satan, and surround yourself with other believers. Pray regularly, and keep reading the Bible.

God our Savior…wants all men to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth. **(1 Timothy 2:3-4)**[56]

For my Father's will is that everyone who looks to the Son and believes in him shall have eternal life, and I will raise him up at the last day. **(John 6:40)**[57]

I tell you the truth, whoever hears my word and believes him who sent me has eternal life and will not be condemned; he has crossed over from death to life. **(John 5:24)**[58]